Jefferson Leal

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EDUCATION

University of Rochester

Ph.D. Political Science (Expected Spring 2027)
- Dissertation: Three Essays on Ideology, Populism, and Polarization
- Fields: Comparative Politics, Political Methodology, Formal Theory (Minor)
- Concentration: Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning
- Committee: Anderson Frey (chair), Gretchen Helmke, Alexander Lee

M.A. Political Science, STEM-certified (2024)

University of São Paulo

M.Sc. Political Science (2019)
- Thesis: Partisan Ideology and Personal Income Tax Policymaking in Brazil (*in Portuguese*)
- Advisor: Marta Arretche

B.A. Economics (2018)

B.A. International Relations (2012)

RESEARCH INTERESTS

- Substantive: Comparative Politics, Latin America, Populism, Polarization, Public Policy
- Methodological: Causal Inference, Text-as-Data, Machine Learning, Large Language Models

RESEARCH

Publications

Frey, A.; Leal, J. When Crisis Hits, Does Experience Matter? Evidence from COVID-19 Vaccination. Conditionally accepted at the *British Journal of Political Science*.

Book Chapters

2020 Lazzari, E.; Leal, J. Brazilian Tax Policy under the Lens of Inequality: Stable, Persistent, and Durable Regressivity. In: Arretche, M.; Marques, E.; Faria, C. (eds.), *The Policies of Politics: Inequality and Inclusion in the Governments of the Workers' Party and the Social Democratic Party*. São Paulo: UNESP Publishing. (*in Portuguese*)
Volume received Honorable Mention, 6th ABEU Awards (Brazilian Association of University Press Publishers)

Working Papers

Leal, J. Which Issues Divide? Interpretable Ideal-Point Estimation from Political Text.

Leal, J. Local Right-Wing Populism and Vaccination: Evidence from the COVID-19 Pandemic in Brazil.

Leal, J. The Negative Ideological Reverse Coattail Effect: Reversing Democratic Backsliding in Brazil.

Leal, J. Why Do Citizens Support Non-Democratic Ideas? Evidence from Latin America.

Work in Progress

Frey, A.; Caetano, G.; Caetano, C.; Leal, J. Treatment Effects with a Bunching Design in Politics: Evidence from Targeted Transfers.

Frey, A.; Leal, J. Ideological Alignment and Local Policy Provision: Public Security Spending in Brazil.

Policy Reports

2020 Prates, I.; Barbosa, R.; Leal, J. Black men and Black women are the most vulnerable in the crisis; however, a "new vulnerable" group emerges: White men and White women in non-essential services. Bulletin No. 3. Solidary Research Network.

2020 Prates, I.; Barbosa, R.; Leal, J. et al. Emergency benefit providing R$600 needs to continue and could be funded by an emergency contribution on high incomes. Bulletin No. 8. Solidary Research Network.

Research Assistantships

2026 Research Assistant to Gretchen Helmke, University of Rochester
Code review and methodological audit of conjoint experiment implementation.

2022–26 Research Assistant to Anderson Frey, University of Rochester
Web scraping, HPC-based data processing, and text-based measurement design.

2024–25 Research Assistant to Bonnie Meguid, University of Rochester
Human coding of femonationalism in European parliamentary speech corpora.

PRESENTATIONS

Invited Talks

07/2026 Blalock Lecture Series, ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods, University of Michigan

04/2026 GIGA Institute for Latin American Studies, Hamburg, Germany

08/2017 Book conference for *The Policies of Politics*, Center for Metropolitan Studies (CEM), University of São Paulo

Conference Presentations

2026 PolMeth
APSA Annual Meeting
APSA Preconference in Political Communication & Politics and Computational Social Science

2025 PolMeth

2024 PolMeth
Latin American PolMeth
MPSA Annual Conference
Summer Institute in Computational Social Science (SICSS), University of Rochester

2023 PolMeth
APSA Annual Meeting

2021 MPSA Annual Conference

GRANTS AND AWARDS

Scholarships

2026–27 Democracy Center Graduate Fellowship, University of Rochester

2025 NSF Conference Travel Grant, Society for Political Methodology

2023–24 W. Allen Wallis Institute of Political Economy Fellowship, University of Rochester

2023 NSF Conference Travel Grant, Society for Political Methodology

2022–26 Lanni Summer Research Grant, Department of Political Science, University of Rochester

2022 Program in Empirical Policy Research (PEPR) Grant, W. Allen Wallis Institute of Political Economy, University of Rochester

2016–18 Master's Fellowship (CAPES), Brazilian Ministry of Education

2015 Undergraduate Research Assistantship, Department of Economics, University of São Paulo

Awards

2024 Graduate Student Teaching Assistant Award, Department of Political Science, University of Rochester

2024 Beck Third-Year Paper Award, Department of Political Science, University of Rochester

2024 Best Paper, SICSS, University of Rochester

2017 3rd Best Poster, 7th IPSA São Paulo Summer School in Methods

PROFESSIONAL EMPLOYMENT

Academic Experience

2017–21 Lecturer, Universidade Paulista, Brazil

Non-Academic Experience

2011–13 Planning and Logistics Analyst, Rockwell Automation Brazil
Inventory and distribution planning and statistical forecasting for Brazil, Chile, and Argentina.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

2025–26 ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods, Teaching Assistant
- Matrix Algebra, Calculus, and Probability (Grad.), Summer 2025; 2026, Prof. Tim McDaniel
- Causal Inference II (Grad.), Summer 2025; 2026, Prof. Sebastian Calonico and Prof. Nicolás Idrobo

2023–25 University of Rochester, Teaching Assistant
- PSCI 389, Senior Honors Seminar (Undergrad.), Fall 2024; Spring 2025, Prof. Casey Petroff
- PSCI 102, Intro. to International Political Economy (Undergrad.), Spring 2024, Prof. Randall Stone
- PSCI 101, Intro. to Comparative Politics (Undergrad.), Fall 2023, Prof. Bonnie Meguid

2017–21 Universidade Paulista, Instructor of Record
- Integrated Multidisciplinary Project (Undergrad.), 1st & 2nd sem. 2019–2021
- International Business (Undergrad.), 2nd sem. 2019–2021
- International Marketing (Undergrad.), 2nd sem. 2021
- Geopolitics and Global Markets (Undergrad.), 1st sem. 2021
- Intro. to the Social Sciences (Undergrad.), 2nd sem. 2019, 2020
- Brazilian Culture (Undergrad.), 2nd sem. 2018, 2019; 1st sem. 2020
- Economics & Markets (Undergrad.), 1st sem. 2020
- International Politics and Economics (Undergrad.), 1st sem. 2020
- Microeconomics II (Undergrad.), 1st sem. 2020
- Intro. to Statistics (Undergrad.), 2nd sem. 2019
- Microeconomics I (Undergrad.), 2nd sem. 2019

2020 IPSA São Paulo Summer School in Methods, Teaching Assistant
- Survey Design (Grad.), Jan–Feb 2020, Prof. Bruno Cautrès
- Survey Analysis (Grad.), Jan–Feb 2020, Prof. Bruno Cautrès

2018 Department of Political Science, University of São Paulo, Teaching Assistant
- FLP0406, Research Methods and Techniques in Political Science (Grad./Undergrad.), 1st sem. 2018, Prof. Glauco Peres

INSTRUCTIONAL MATERIALS

Co-authored Instructional Materials

2017–21 Universidade Paulista, Office of Academic Quality (*in Portuguese*)

- Instructional Material for International Relations, Volume VII, 2018
- Instructional Material for International Relations, Volumes VIII, IX, X, and XI, 2021
- Instructional Material for Economics, Volumes VII, VIII, and IX, 2018
- Instructional Material for Social Sciences, Volumes I and III, 2017
- Instructional Material for Social Sciences, Volumes IV, V, and VI, 2020
- Nationwide Institutional Standardized Exam in International Relations, 2018
- Simulation Questionnaires for International Relations and Economics, 2017–2021
- Verbal and Quantitative Reasoning Questions, one set per semester, 2018–2021

Distance-learning Textbooks Refereed

2019–21 Universidade Paulista, Office of Academic Quality, Referee for textbooks (*in Portuguese*)
- International Law, Jul 2021
- Contemporary International Relations, Jun 2021
- International Relations in Latin America, May 2021
- Contemporary Theories of International Relations, Apr 2021
- Political Diplomacy in International Relations, Apr 2021
- Statistics and Probability, Apr 2021
- Public and International Relations, Oct 2020
- Foreign Trade and Logistics Studies, Oct 2020
- Processes and Practices in International Relations, Oct 2020
- Theories of International Relations, Oct 2020
- Topics in Applied Mathematics, Oct 2020
- Sectoral Policy: Health, Apr 2020
- Social Projects in the Third Sector, Oct 2019

AFFILIATIONS & SERVICE

2025 Co-organizer, SICSS, University of Rochester

2023–24 President, International Student and Scholar Advisory Board (ISSAB), University of Rochester

2022–23 Chair of Communications, ISSAB, University of Rochester

2020–21 Referee, *Leviathan: Cadernos de Pesquisa Política* (Political Research Papers)

2017–21 Referee for Instructional Materials, Office of Academic Quality, Universidade Paulista

2016–20 Junior Researcher, Center for Metropolitan Studies

2016–20 Member, Inequalities Studies Group, University of São Paulo

COMPUTATIONAL AND QUANTITATIVE SKILLS

- Programming and Software: R, Python, Stata, MATLAB, LaTeX, GeoDa
- Tools and Skills: SLURM, Claude Code, Codex, Web Scraping
- Quantitative Methods: Causal Inference, Survey Design and Analysis, Machine Learning, Deep Learning, Natural Language Processing, Spatial Analysis

ADDITIONAL TRAINING

2019 Graduate Certificate in Legislative Politics and Public Policy, School of Government Administration and Accounting of São Paulo

2019 Survey Analysis, Design, and Experiments, IPSA São Paulo Summer School in Methods

2018 Teaching Improvement Program (120 hours), University of São Paulo

2018 Modeling Dynamics in Space and Time, IPSA São Paulo Summer School in Methods

2017 Advanced Issues in Multi-Method Research: Integrating Case Studies and Contemporary Methods for Causal Inference, IPSA São Paulo Summer School in Methods

2016 Summer Workshop on Public Policy, São Paulo City Hall

LANGUAGES

- English: fluent (speaking, reading, writing)
- Spanish: fluent (speaking, reading, writing)
- Portuguese: native (speaking, reading, writing)
- French: advanced (reading, writing); intermediate (speaking)

REFERENCES

Anderson Frey
Associate Professor
Department of Political Science
University of Rochester
✉ anderson.frey@rochester.edu

Gretchen Helmke
Thomas H. Jackson Distinguished University Professor
Department of Political Science
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Alexander Lee
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